

Cloudspotting

Clouds come in many shapes and sizes—some large and fluffy, some small and wispy. It all depends on whether they are formed from water droplets or ice crystals. Weather experts identify clouds by how high they are in the sky, and whether they are layered (stratus) or in heaps (cumulus).

Nimbostratus

These thick layers of cloud start near the ground and can be very tall. They can bring hours of rain or snow.

Cirrostratus

Clouds that form very high in the sky always start with the word “cirro.” Cirrostratus clouds are made of ice crystals.

Altostratus

Medium-height clouds start with the word “alto.” Altostratus is a layer of cloud made of water droplets.

Stratus

Thick layers of stratus cloud hang close to the ground. Sometimes the Sun can be seen through them, looking like a silver disk.